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Cuba Healthcare & Education Systems Viewed As Success

(This is a guest Column written by Luther Washington, COPE Director for the Greater Kansas City AFL-CIO and Troy Nash, Kansas City City Councilman)

Recently, we were invited by the "People to People" Ambassador program to join a delegation to Cuba. Question: Who could find fault with a country known for its tropical climate, rum, and cigars? Answer: Fidel Castro.

Despite these enemies, Castro built a country in which healthcare and education are viewed as successes throughout the region. One indicator for the quality of a country's healthcare system is the infant mortality rate. Prior to the revolution, Cubas's infant mortality rate was 60 percent of every 1000 births. Now, it stands at 7.1 for every 1000 births-ranking it among the lowest in the world. Healthcare is free and widespread.



Luther Washington



Troy Nash

Before the revolution, twenty five percent of the Cuban adults were illiterate. Another million were semi-illiterate. And, seventy percent of the rural communities had no schools. Cuba's present literacy rate is 94.5 percent. And, education if free from kindergarten through university and universal..

But, Castro did not accomplish this by himself.

Revolution stimulated these changes in Cuba. Prior to the revolution, land was owned by a few. Poverty and unemployment was extremely high.

And, education and healthcare for the ordinary Cuban citizen was nonexistent. Change was in-evitable. Certainly, a revolution was inevitalble. At the vanguard of the revolution were students, peasants and trade unionists. After the revolution the students got universal and free education. The peasants got land reform. And, the trade unionist got a large say in how Cuba's economy is run. But, what has happened to them since the revolution?

Autonomous trade unions are not present in Cuba. However, trade unions are prevalent. Membership in the trade unions give workers a say in production decisions and investment. The most important party controlled mass organization is the Confederation de Tradajadores Cubanos, a trade organization with over 80,000 local branches. Open and frank discussion are present within assemblies within this group. And vigorous debate centers on economic issues and problems - both national and local. Union leaders receive no additional pay for their role. As a result, those individuals who are dedicated and articulate spokespersons rise to the top through elections. Cubans employed in the tourist industry earn an average of $10 US or more per month, however, there is the opportunity to earn much more in tips. Tour guides can make $500-600 US per excursion. At the low end, hotel housekeepers make an average of $1 to 2 per day, per room. Considering, that the average wage of most Cubans is around $20 per month, jobs in these industries are highly prized. They usually go to individuals who excel in language skills or are party members. And, in fact, you may not hold these positions if you have engaged in "anti-social behavior," undermining Cuba's independence to the state economy.

In the Corona Cigar Factory, the average wage was $20 US per month, however, workers received other benefits. The cigar factory workers take home two cigars a day and they usually sell them. The workers are also allowed to smoke as many cigars while at work as they like. Added to these benefits, the workers gain from meeting production goals. They received a bonus for exceeding these goals. In most cases, it was not difficult to receive $40 US per month. Workers began their day around 8:00 am and finished around 4:00pm. They are given an hour for lunch which is usually subsidized by the company. The factory provided employees with lunch for one peso, the equivalent of 10 cents US. They work for 5 days one week then six the next.

Some worker's benefits are very good such as maternal care and maternal leave policy. If a women is pregnant, she usually works until her 7th month and then she can take off until her child is three months old, the mother can take any amount of time off that she wishes and she received up to 50 percent pay for one year. In fact, the employee has the right to her job for one year, even if she chooses not to work. In some respects, this policy is similar to our National Family Leave Act.

Any mention of workers' rights or conditions would be remiss without talking about retirement. According to one source, "Women retire at the age of 55 while Cuban men retire at 60. The men, if they are in mining to another hard industry, may retire at 55. After reaching retirement age, many workers choose instead to continue working to earn supplement income. Pension benefits vary according to the length of one' service. The benefit represents a percentage of the person's salary. Senior citizens without family to support or take care of them live free of charge in hogares de ancianos."

During our trip, we failed to see anyone begging, homeless, or malnourished. But, freedom of speech, as we understand it, is significantly curtailed. However,. the involvement of trade unions in the decision making is substantial. They are involved in the decision making process from establishing the economic goals of the country, down to the shop floor. And, they decide about the priorities for slicing up the economic pie.